

loan services. It isn't insurance. And it isn't taxes. It's everything. A real financial planner is going to take a personal approach to your financial situation. They should sit down with you and analyze your entire financial situation. Income, expenses, assets, liabilities, insurance, and even some of the intangibles like your personal approach and attitudes toward money. They should be interested in what you want to accomplish with your life, what major purchases you have in your future, what sorts of vacations you like to take, and how you envision your retirement years. They also need to know your personal tolerance for risk and fluctuation in your investments, and should coach you on it. If they don't do all these things, they can't properly advise you!

6. Won't this cost a ton?

Financial planning actually doesn't have to cost you a penny out of your pocket, depending on the planner and where you go for your services. Many banks have a team of financial planners who are available to help the bank's clients. They are paid a salary by the bank, and often don't cost you a thing. You can also choose asset-based advisors who again, you won't have to pay for out of pocket, but who are only compensated by their employer

based on the money you invest with them. Believe it or not, this doesn't mean that you necessarily need a ton of money to invest; many of these advisors want long-term relationships and believe they can help you over the long run and will ultimately be compensated for it. And of course, there are also fee-based planners and those with other methods of compensation.

7. Who is best for me?

What you need to look for in a planner first and foremost is somebody you like. If you're going to share details about your financial life and dreams and expectations, you need to feel comfortable opening up to them and establishing a relationship of trust.

8. Can't I do all this on my own?

There are a ton of solutions out there on the Internet. My response to that is: Do you have a life? The job of a financial planner is a full-time gig. They know a lot and need to stay up-to-date in the ever-changing world of finance. If you keep up with all the latest tax legislation, investment regulations, and insurance opportunities and lingo, then be my guest and give it a whirl. What you'll still be missing is a third-party perspective, and possibly some creative strategies